

CHAPTER 9 — Prepared

They passed a sign for services, but Elias continued beyond the junction. Zoe had not asked to stop, and for the first time since the airport, he did not think she needed to.

“What did they want from you?” he asked.

Zoe did not answer straight away. She watched a lorry overtake them, slow and heavy, before she spoke.

“At first I didn’t know,” she said. “I just knew there were rules.”

She woke in a different room from the one she had been locked in the first night.

It was smaller. Bars had been fitted inside the window frame and painted the same white as the wall, easy to miss at a glance. Someone had left clothes folded at the end of the bed.

Grey.

Plain.

Nothing that belonged to her.

A woman Zoe had not seen before entered without knocking and recited the rules in the even, unhurried voice of someone who had said them many times.

Don’t speak unless spoken to.

Don’t ask questions.

Don’t look the buyers in the eye.

Zoe asked what a buyer was.

The woman studied her for several seconds. Her expression did not change, but something in it made the question feel like another rule Zoe had already broken.

Then she left without answering.

Later, Zoe was taken downstairs to a room with too many chairs.

Six children sat inside. She counted them immediately, though she suspected there were others elsewhere in the house. None looked directly at anyone else.

She understood, without being told, that this was another rule.

A girl no older than ten flinched when a man passed too close.

He noticed.

He crouched beside her and said something too quietly for Zoe to hear. The girl went rigid, staring at one point on the floor until he stood and walked away.

Zoe watched, made herself very small and said nothing.

It was in that room, on the second afternoon, that she first heard the name.

Two of the older children whispered near the wall.

Quick.

Low.

The whispering stopped the moment an adult's shadow crossed the doorway, but Zoe had already caught fragments.

If Cain finds out.

Cain doesn't care.

Nobody argues with Cain.

She turned the name over privately for the rest of the day.

Nobody whispered it as though it belonged to someone who could be reasoned with.

"Was that the only time?" Elias asked. "Someone punished for a small thing?"

"No."

Her voice had flattened again. Elias had noticed it before: whenever she described something instead of allowing herself to feel it, the words became precise and distant.

“It happened a lot,” she said. “It wasn’t really about the rule. It was to remind everyone the rules existed.”

Elias kept his eyes on the road.

“That’s not discipline,” he said. “That’s a demonstration.”

Zoe glanced at him in the mirror.

“You know that because—?”

“Because I’ve seen people run rooms like that before.”

He offered nothing more.

She did not ask.

Not yet.

Later that afternoon, a man arrived.

Nobody introduced him.

They did not need to.

Every conversation stopped before he reached the doorway. One of the adults stepped aside without being asked. The woman who had given Zoe the rules straightened so quickly that the movement looked rehearsed.

Cain.

He did not look at any of the children.

He walked through to a study at the back of the house. The woman followed him inside and pulled the door closed.

A few minutes later, she came back out carrying a water jug.

“Fill this,” she told Zoe.

She turned and went back into the study. The door did not quite latch behind her. As Zoe passed, she heard Cain speaking inside.

"Buyer confirmed," the woman said.

"Documentation?"

"Pending."

A pause followed. Paper moved against paper.

"And the older file?"

"Filed under the original number. Nothing's changed."

Zoe did not understand the words.

She understood the change in their voices.

Both had become quieter. More careful. Each sentence placed as precisely as a foot on uncertain ground.

She was still near the doorway when it opened.

The woman almost walked into her.

"Water," Zoe said, raising the empty jug.

The woman's gaze remained on her for one beat too long.

She stepped out carrying a folder. Then a phone began vibrating in her pocket.

She placed the folder on the kitchen counter before answering the call and moving several steps away.

The folder lay half-open.

A number had been written on the tab instead of a name.

The woman did not close it. She did not turn it over. She did not appear to consider that Zoe might understand anything she saw.

A photograph lay on top of the papers.

A young girl, perhaps six or seven, with her hair in two plaits. She had been caught laughing at something outside the frame.

Zoe stared at the picture while the jug filled.

The face felt familiar before she understood why.

It was hers.

Younger.

A photograph she did not remember anyone taking.

The tap continued running until water reached the rim and spilled across her fingers.

Zoe turned it off.

The woman was still speaking quietly into the phone.

Zoe left the jug on the counter and returned to the room with too many chairs.

She said nothing.

She looked at no one.

She knew the folder concerned her. She knew the adults had kept a photograph of her for years. She knew there was a number connected to her that existed before she understood any of this.

She did not yet know what the number meant.

She did not know who the buyer was.

She did not know why somebody had been keeping records on her since she was a small child.

But she knew she had not been taken at random.

Elias let the silence settle after that part.

In the mirror, Zoe was watching him. He kept his face still, although the muscle in his jaw tightened once before he made it stop.

"You knew the folder was about you," he said.

"I knew it had my photograph."

"But not what it represented."

“No. I didn’t know what the number meant, why the picture was years old or how long they’d been keeping records on me.”

Elias looked ahead.

“And Cain?”

“I knew who everyone in that house was afraid of.”

“When did you understand what they were preparing you for?”

Zoe’s fingers found the strap of the backpack in her lap.

“Not all at once,” she said. “That night, they stopped letting me sleep.”